

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Electric school bus maker Lion faces likely liquidation

Sprawling plant touted the potential for 1,400 new jobs when it opened in 2023

By **Nara Schoenberg**
Chicago Tribune

Lion Electric opened its sprawling 900,000-square-foot plant near Joliet in 2023, touting the potential for 1,400 new jobs.

The Quebec-based electric school bus maker found eager customers in Illinois school districts, which wanted to take advantage of generous federal

grants, reduce pollution and give kids a cleaner, quieter ride to school.

But the bad news about Lion, which has been building for months, got worse Monday, with a court-appointed monitor saying there is a “very high” likelihood that the company will be liquidated, according to the Globe and Mail and other outlets.

“It’s a bit of a sad story, because

it’s the right company with an interesting product,” said Yan Cimon, a professor of business strategy at the Université Laval in Québec City. He said Lion followed an ambitious path — including a bold expansion into the United States — and ultimately the company’s sales didn’t keep up.

“Had Lion been a bit more conservative, maybe they wouldn’t be where they are,” he said.

Illinois Gov. JB Pritzker, a strong proponent of clean energy, attended the opening of Lion’s now-shuttered Illinois plant in

■ Rivian building \$120M supplier park in Normal to increase EV production. **Business**

2023, along with both Illinois senators.

“Illinois has made tremendous strides turning the state into a manufacturing hub for electric vehicles,” the governor’s press secretary, Alex Gough, said Monday in a written statement.

“Governor Pritzker remains committed to maintaining an ecosystem where EV companies

and their employees are able to thrive,” the statement said. “Just this morning, (electric vehicle-maker) Rivian made a major commitment to their growth in Illinois by bringing a supplier park to Normal.”

Rivian is constructing a new 1.2 million-square-foot supplier park in Normal, according to a news release from the company. As part of that, Rivian will invest nearly \$120 million, which will enable the company to develop the supplier

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Steppenwolf Theatre play ‘Purpose’ wins Pulitzer

Debuted in Chicago in 2024; loosely based on family of Jesse Jackson

By **Chris Jones**
and **Doug George**
Chicago Tribune

“Purpose,” a play by Branden Jacobs-Jenkins that was commissioned by Chicago’s Steppenwolf Theatre Company, has won the 2025 Pulitzer Prize for drama, the Pulitzer board announced Monday.

The fictional work debuted in Chicago in 2024 and moved earlier this year from Steppenwolf to Broadway, where it currently plays with most of its original Chicago cast. Directed in New York and Chicago by Phylicia Rashad, it’s loosely based on the family of civil rights leader Jesse Jackson.

This marks the first time a play first seen at Steppenwolf has won the prestigious prize since Tracy Letts’ “August: Osage County” in 2008.

In a joint statement to the Tribune, Steppenwolf artistic directors Glenn Davis and Audrey Francis said that the “Purpose” win “underscores our company’s time-honored commitment to developing ensemble-driven, new works.” The play was also nominated for a Tony Award last week, along with several members of its cast.

The 2025 winners of the Pulitzer Prizes, presented annually by Columbia University, include nine winners across eight arts categories for books, drama and music. Awards for journalism were also announced Monday.

“James,” by the novelist Percival Everett, won for fiction.

The book, which previously won the Kirkus Prize and a National Book Award and was shortlisted for the Booker Prize, used Mark Twain’s “The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn” as its starting point, reworking the story from the perspective of Jim, now James, Twain’s escaped slave. It was a risky kind of bestseller from a longtime author and professor of English at the University of

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‘Snap’ curfew vote delayed again

Aldermen once again delayed an expected vote on whether Chicago police should get the power to implement “snap” curfews to try to force large youth gatherings to break up. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Offering \$1,000 to self-deport

Pushing forward with its mass deportation agenda, President Donald Trump’s administration said that it would pay \$1,000 to immigrants who are in the United States illegally and return to their home country voluntarily. **Nation & World**



U.S. Rep. Jan Schakowsky, center, weeps with staffers Leslie Combs, right, and Taina Rodriguez while standing for photos at the Sheraton Grand Chicago Riverwalk on Monday after she announced she will not run for reelection next year. **EILEENT.MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

US Rep. Schakowsky announces she will not seek another term

Has represented a Far North Side and north and northwest suburban district since 1999

By **Olivia Olander**
Chicago Tribune

U.S. Rep. Jan Schakowsky, who represented a Far North Side and north and northwest suburban district in Congress for more than 2½ decades, announced Monday that she will not seek a 15th term next year.

“This is the official — that I’m not going to run again for Congress,” Schakowsky said to a crowd of about 1,000 people attending an Ultimate Women’s Power Luncheon event she hosted at the Sheraton Grand

Chicago Hotel. “As much as I love and have loved being in the Congress of the United States, such an incredible, incredible privilege to work with the people of the district, to learn from them, to be an organizer, to be a fighter — well, that will never end. But I have made the decision that I am not going to seek reelection this time.”

The move marks the end of an era for a reliably Democratic district that Schakowsky, 80, of Evanston, has represented since 1999 after soundly defeating two opponents, including JB Pritzker,

in an open-seat primary. Before her, Sidney Yates held the seat for 24 terms, almost 50 years.

Her retirement will undoubtedly set off a series of political maneuvers. Even before Schakowsky’s announcement, a social media content creator had declared candidacy for the seat: 26-year-old Kat Abughazaleh, a progressive critic of the far right who moved to Illinois last year [JUMP] and outraised Schakowsky in the first quarter.

Abughazaleh will almost certainly be joined by a field of Democratic hopefuls that could

include Evanston Mayor Daniel Biss, state Sen. Laura Fine, state Rep. Hoan Huynh and others.

Schakowsky declined to say Monday whether she’d support any particular candidate to succeed her.

Biss and Fine, who were at the luncheon, both declined to discuss whether they were interested in the seat.

“This is a day to talk about Jan’s remarkable legacy,” Biss said. “I just feel really fortunate to have a leader like her in this role, and

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As aquifer dries up, some Will County towns say they aren’t worried about losing water



Adithya Salil Nair, a field engineer with Stantec, and Berkay Azakli, a geotechnical engineer with SEECO Consultants, write a plan March 14 to collect samples from a former cornfield where Joliet hopes to build a water tower and pumping station. **AUDREY RICHARDSON/TRIBUNE**

By **Cathy Ching**
Chicago Tribune

As Joliet races to meet state requirements to be eligible to tap into Lake Michigan water before the region’s groundwater is depleted, a handful of neighboring towns are holding off on making plans to identify alternative sources.

About 35 miles southwest of Chicago, Joliet is at the epicenter of a regional water crisis where many suburbs will run out of water supplied by the Cambrian-Ordovician aquifer by 2030, according to estimations in a 2018 report by the Illinois State Water Survey.

Construction of the Joliet pipeline is slated to start next month and is being funded by the Grand

Prairie Water Commission, which includes Joliet and the towns of Channahon, Crest Hill, Minooka, Romeoville and Shorewood.

Meanwhile, officials with Elwood, Lemont, Lockport, Manhattan and Morris say they believe even a depleting aquifer will be able to meet their water needs in the future.

However, the challenge with these towns staying on the aquifer is the unpredictability and sensitivity of the deep aquifer, said Daniel Abrams, the principal investigator of the aquifer for the Illinois State Water Survey.

“Can they persist into the future? Yes,” Abrams said. “Will it be a resource that can always meet their water needs? That

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